'Well,' said Porthos, 'if any one had told you in the old times that the day would come when Planchet would rescue Rochefort and that you would protect him in it— '

'I should not have believed him; but men are changed by events.'

'There is nothing truer than that,' said Porthos; 'but what does not change, or changes for the better, is wine. Taste of this; it is a Spanish wine which our friend Athos thought much of.'

At that moment the steward came in to consult his master upon the proceedings of the next day and also with regard to the shooting party which had been proposed.

'Tell me, Mouston,' said Porthos, 'are my arms in good condition?'

'Your arms, my lord—what arms?'

'Zounds! my weapons.'

'What weapons?'

'My military weapons.'

'Yes, my lord; at any rate, I *think* so.'

'Make sure of it, and if they want it, have them burnished up. Which is my best cavalry horse?'

'Vulcan.'

'And the best hack?'

'Bayard.'

'What horse dost thou choose for thyself?'

'I like Rustaud, my lord; a good animal, whose paces suit me.'

'Strong, thinkest thou?'

'Half Norman, half Mecklenburger; will go night and day.'

'That will do for us. See to these horses. Polish up or make some one else polish my arms. Then take pistols with thee and a hunting-knife.'

'Are we then going to travel, my lord?' asked Mousqueton, rather uneasy.

'Something better still, Mouston.'

'An expedition, sir?' asked the steward, whose roses began to change into lilies.

'We are going to return to the service, Mouston,' replied Porthos, still trying to restore his mustache to the military curl it had long lost.

'Into the service—the king's service?' Mousqueton trembled; even his fat, smooth cheeks shook as he spoke, and he looked at D'Artagnan with an air of reproach; he staggered, and his voice was almost choked.

'Yes and no. We shall serve in a campaign, seek out all sorts of adventures—return, in short, to our former life.'

These last words fell on Mousqueton like a thunderbolt. It was those very terrible old days that made the present so excessively delightful, and the blow was so great he rushed out, overcome, and forgot to shut the door.

The two friends remained alone to speak of the future and to build castles in the air. The good wine which Mousqueton had placed before them traced out in glowing drops to D'Artagnan a fine perspective, shining with quadruples and pistoles, and showed to Porthos a blue ribbon and a ducal mantle; they were, in fact, asleep on the table when the servants came to light them to their bed.

Mousqueton was, however, somewhat consoled by D'Artagnan, who the next day told him that in all probability war would always be carried on in the heart of Paris and within reach of the Château du Vallon, which was near Corbeil, or Bracieux, which was near Melun, and of Pierrefonds, which was between Compiègne and Villars-Cotterets.

'But—formerly—it appears,' began Mousqueton timidly.

'Oh!' said D'Artagnan, 'we don't now make war as we did formerly. To-day it's a sort of diplomatic arrangement; ask Planchet.'

Mousqueton inquired, therefore, the state of the case of his old friend, who confirmed the statement of D'Artagnan. 'But,' he added, 'in this war prisoners stand a chance of being hung.'

'The deuce they do!' said Mousqueton; 'I think I should like the siege of Rochelle better than this war, then!'

Porthos, meantime, asked D'Artagnan to give him his instructions how to proceed on his journey.

'Four days,' replied his friend, 'are necessary to reach Blois; one day to rest there; three or four days to return to Paris. Set out, therefore, in a week, with your suite, and go to the Hotel de la Chevrette, Rue Tiquetonne, and there await me.'

'That's agreed,' said Porthos.

'As to myself, I shall go around to see Athos; for though I don't think his aid worth much, one must with one's friends observe all due politeness,' said D'Artagnan.

The friends then took leave of each other on the very border of the estate of Pierrefonds, to which Porthos escorted his friend.

'At least,' D'Artagnan said to himself, as he took the road to Villars-Cotterets, 'at least I shall not be alone in my undertaking. That devil, Porthos, is a man of prodigious strength; still, if Athos joins us, well, we shall be three of us to laugh at Aramis, that little coxcomb with his too good luck.'

At Villars-Cotterets he wrote to the cardinal:

> My Lord,
>
> I have already one man to offer to your eminence, and he is well worth twenty men. I am just setting out for Blois. The Comte de la Fère inhabits the Castle of Bragelonne, in the environs of that city.

'Eh! why, it is after one o'clock.'

'Your home is a paradise, Porthos; one takes no note of time. I follow you, though I am not hungry.'

'Come, if one can't always eat, one can always drink—a maxim of poor Athos, the truth of which I have discovered since I began to be lonely.'

D'Artagnan, who as a Gascon, was inclined to sobriety, seemed not so sure as his friend of the truth of Athos's maxim, but he did his best to keep up with his host. Meanwhile his misgivings in regard to Mousqueton recurred to his mind and with greater force because Mousqueton, though he did not himself wait on the table, which would have been beneath him in his new position, appeared at the door from time to time and evinced his gratitude to D'Artagnan by the quality of the wine he directed to be served. Therefore, when, at dessert, upon a sign from D'Artagnan, Porthos had sent away his servants and the two friends were alone:

'Porthos,' said D'Artagnan, 'who will attend you in your campaigns?'

'Why,' replied Porthos, 'Mouston, of course.'

This was a blow to D'Artagnan. He could already see the intendant's beaming smile change to a contortion of grief. 'But,' he said, 'Mouston is not so young as he was, my dear fellow; besides, he has grown fat and perhaps has lost his fitness for active service.'

'That may be true,' replied Porthos; 'but I am used to him, and besides, he wouldn't be willing to let me go without him, he loves me so much.'

'Oh, blind self-love!' thought D'Artagnan.

'And you,' asked Porthos, 'haven't you still in your service your old lackey, that good, that brave, that intelligent—-what, then, is his name?'

'Planchet—yes, I have found him again, but he is lackey no longer.'

'What is he, then?'

'With his sixteen hundred francs—you remember, the sixteen hundred francs he earned at the siege of La Rochelle by carrying a letter to Lord de Winter—he has set up a little shop in the Rue des Lombards and is now a confectioner.'

'Ah, he is a confectioner in the Rue des Lombards! How does it happen, then, that he is in your service?'

'He has been guilty of certain escapades and fears he may be disturbed.' And the musketeer narrated to his friend Planchet's adventure.

'Well, speak, if it depends on me.'

'Oh, sir! it depends on you only.'

'I listen—I am waiting to hear.'

'Sir, the favour I have to ask of you is, not to call me "Mousqueton" but "Mouston." Since I have had the honour of being my lord's steward I have taken the last name as more dignified and calculated to make my inferiors respect me. You, sir, know how necessary subordination is in any large establishment of servants.'

D'Artagnan smiled; Porthos wanted to lengthen out his names, Mousqueton to cut his short.

'Well, my dear Mouston,' he said, 'rest satisfied. I will call thee Mouston; and if it makes thee happy I will not "tutoyer"[1] you any longer.'

'Oh!' cried Mousqueton, reddening with joy; 'if you do me, sir, such honour, I shall be grateful all my life; it is too much to ask.'

'Alas!' thought D'Artagnan, 'it is very little to offset the unexpected tribulations I am bringing to this poor devil who has so warmly welcomed me.'

'Will monsieur remain long with us?' asked Mousqueton, with a serene and glowing countenance.

'I go to-morrow, my friend,' replied D'Artagnan.

'Ah, monsieur,' said Mousqueton, 'then you have come here only to awaken our regrets.'

'I fear that is true,' said D'Artagnan, in a low tone.

D'Artagnan was secretly touched with remorse, not at inducing Porthos to enter into schemes in which his life and fortune would be in jeopardy, for Porthos, in the title of baron, had his object and reward; but poor Mousqueton, whose only wish was to be called Mouston—was it not cruel to snatch him from the delightful state of peace and plenty in which he was?

He was thinking of these matters when Porthos summoned him to dinner.

'What! to dinner?' said D'Artagnan. 'What time is it, then?'

[1] i.e. address him with the pronoun *tu*, which is used for social inferiors, instead of *vous*, which is used for social equals and superiors. This translation renders *tu* as *thee/thou* and *vous* as *you*.

Chapter XIII

Two Angelic Faces

THE road was long, but the horses upon which D'Artagnan and Planchet rode had been refreshed in the well supplied stables of the Lord of Bracieux; the master and servant rode side by side, conversing as they went, for D'Artagnan had by degrees thrown off the master and Planchet had entirely ceased to assume the manners of a servant. He had been raised by circumstances to the rank of a confidant to his master. It was many years since D'Artagnan had opened his heart to any one; it happened, however, that these two men, on meeting again, assimilated perfectly. Planchet was in truth no vulgar companion in these new adventures; he was a man of uncommonly sound sense. Without courting danger he never shrank from an encounter; in short, he had been a soldier and arms ennoble a man; it was, therefore, on the footing of friends that D'Artagnan and Planchet arrived in the neighbourhood of Blois.

Going along, D'Artagnan, shaking his head, said:

'I know that my going to Athos is useless and absurd; but still I owe this courtesy to my old friend, a man who had in him material for the most noble and generous of characters.'

'Oh, Monsieur Athos was a noble gentleman,' said Planchet, 'was he not? Scattering money round about him as Heaven sprinkles rain. Do you remember, sir, that duel with the Englishman in the inclosure des Carmes? Ah! how lofty, how magnificent Monsieur Athos was that day, when he said to his adversary: "You have insisted on knowing my name, sir; so much the worse for you, since I shall be obliged to kill you." I was near him, those were his exact words, when he stabbed his foe as he

said he would, and his adversary fell without saying, "Oh!" 'Tis a noble gentleman—Monsieur Athos.'

'Yes, true as Gospel,' said D'Artagnan; 'but one single fault has swallowed up all these fine qualities.'

'I remember well,' said Planchet, 'he was fond of drinking—in truth, he drank, but not as other men drink. One seemed, as he raised the wine to his lips, to hear him say, "Come, juice of the grape, and chase away my sorrows." And how he used to break the stem of a glass or the neck of a bottle! There was no one like him for that.'

'And now,' replied D'Artagnan, 'behold the sad spectacle that awaits us. This noble gentleman with his lofty glance, this handsome cavalier, so brilliant in feats of arms that every one was surprised that he held in his hand a sword only instead of a baton of command! Alas! we shall find him changed into a broken down old man, with garnet nose and eyes that slobber; we shall find him extended on some lawn, whence he will look at us with a languid eye and peradventure will not recognise us. God knows, Planchet, that I should fly from a sight so sad if I did not wish to show my respect for the illustrious shadow of what was once the Comte de la Fère, whom we loved so much.'

Planchet shook his head and said nothing. It was evident that he shared his master's apprehensions.

'And then,' resumed D'Artagnan, 'to this decrepitude is probably added poverty, for he must have neglected the little that he had, and the dirty scoundrel, Grimaud, more taciturn than ever and still more drunken than his master—stay, Planchet, it breaks my heart to merely think of it.'

'I fancy myself there and that I see him staggering and hear him stammering,' said Planchet, in a piteous tone, 'but at all events we shall soon know the real state of things, for I imagine that those lofty walls, now turning ruby in the setting sun, are the walls of Blois.'

'Probably; and those steeples, pointed and sculptured, that we catch a glimpse of yonder, are similar to those that I have heard described at Chambord.'

At this moment one of those heavy wagons, drawn by bullocks, which carry the wood cut in the fine forests of the country to the ports of the Loire, came out of a byroad full of ruts and turned on that which the two horsemen were following. A man carrying a long switch with a nail at the

Chapter XII

Porthos was Discontented with his Condition

s they returned toward the castle, D'Artagnan thought of the miseries of poor human nature, always dissatisfied with what it has, ever desirous of what it has not.

In the position of Porthos, D'Artagnan would have been perfectly happy; and to make Porthos contented there was wanting—what? five letters to put before his three names, a tiny coronet to paint upon the panels of his carriage!

'I shall pass all my life,' thought D'Artagnan, 'in seeking for a man who is really contented with his lot.'

Whilst making this reflection, chance seemed, as it were, to give him the lie direct. When Porthos had left him to give some orders he saw Mousqueton approaching. The face of the steward, despite one slight shade of care, light as a summer cloud, seemed a physiognomy of absolute felicity.

'Here is what I am looking for,' thought D'Artagnan; 'but alas! the poor fellow does not know the purpose for which I am here.'

He then made a sign for Mousqueton to come to him.

'Sir,' said the servant, 'I have a favour to ask you.'

'Speak out, my friend.'

'I am afraid to do so. Perhaps you will think, sir, that prosperity has spoiled me?'

'Art thou happy, friend?' asked D'Artagnan.

'As happy as possible; and yet, sir, you may make me even happier than I am.'

end of it, with which he urged on his slow team, was walking with the cart.

'Ho! friend,' cried Planchet.

'What's your pleasure, gentlemen?' replied the peasant, with a purity of accent peculiar to the people of that district and which might have put to shame the cultured denizens of the Sorbonne and the Rue de l'Université.

'We are looking for the house of Monsieur de la Fère,' said D'Artagnan.

The peasant took off his hat on hearing this revered name.

'Gentlemen,' he said, 'the wood that I am carting is his; I cut it in his copse and I am taking it to the château.'

D'Artagnan determined not to question this man; he did not wish to hear from another what he had himself said to Planchet.

'The château!' he said to himself, 'what château? Ah, I understand! Athos is not a man to be thwarted; he, like Porthos, has obliged his peasantry to call him "my lord," and to dignify his pettifogging place by the name of château. He had a heavy hand—dear old Athos—after drinking.'

D'Artagnan, after asking the man the right way, continued his route, agitated in spite of himself at the idea of seeing once more that singular man whom he had so truly loved and who had contributed so much by advice and example to his education as a gentleman. He checked by degrees the speed of his horse and went on, his head drooping as if in deep thought.

Soon, as the road turned, the Château de la Vallière appeared in view; then, a quarter of a mile beyond, a white house, encircled in sycamores, was visible at the farther end of a group of trees, which spring had powdered with a snow of flowers.

On beholding this house, D'Artagnan, calm as he was in general, felt an unusual disturbance within his heart—so powerful during the whole course of life are the recollections of youth. He proceeded, nevertheless, and came opposite to an iron gate, ornamented in the taste of the period.

Through the gate was seen kitchen-gardens, carefully attended to, a spacious courtyard, in which neighed several horses held by valets in various liveries, and a carriage, drawn by two horses of the country.

'We are mistaken,' said D'Artagnan. 'This cannot be the establishment of Athos. Good heavens! suppose he is dead and that this property now

belongs to some one who bears his name. Alight, Planchet, and inquire, for I confess that I have scarcely courage so to do.'

Planchet alighted.

'Thou must add,' said D'Artagnan, 'that a gentleman who is passing by wishes to have the honour of paying his respects to the Comte de la Fère, and if thou art satisfied with what thou hearest, then mention my name!'

Planchet, leading his horse by the bridle, drew near to the gate and rang the bell, and immediately a servant-man with white hair and of erect stature, notwithstanding his age, presented himself.

'Does Monsieur le Comte de la Fère live here?' asked Planchet.

'Yes, monsieur, it is here he lives,' the servant replied to Planchet, who was not in livery.

'A nobleman retired from service, is he not?'

'Yes.'

'And who had a lackey named Grimaud?' persisted Planchet, who had prudently considered that he couldn't have too much information.

'Monsieur Grimaud is absent from the château for the time being,' said the servitor, who, little used as he was to such inquiries, began to examine Planchet from head to foot.

'Then,' cried Planchet joyously, 'I see well that it is the same Comte de la Fère whom we seek. Be good enough to open to me, for I wish to announce to monsieur le comte that my master, one of his friends, is here, and wishes to greet him.'

'Why didn't you say so?' said the servitor, opening the gate. 'But where is your master?'

'He is following me.'

The servitor opened the gate and walked before Planchet, who made a sign to D'Artagnan. The latter, his heart palpitating more than ever, entered the courtyard without dismounting.

Whilst Planchet was standing on the steps before the house he heard a voice say:

'Well, where is this gentleman and why do they not bring him here?'

This voice, the sound of which reached D'Artagnan, reawakened in his heart a thousand sentiments, a thousand recollections that he had forgotten. He vaulted hastily from his horse, whilst Planchet, with a smile on his lips, advanced toward the master of the house.

'And then he was older than any of us,' added D'Artagnan.

'Some years only. His gravity made him look older than he was.'

'Well then, if we can get Athos, all will be well. If we cannot, we will do without him. We two are worth a dozen.'

'Yes,' said Porthos, smiling at the remembrance of his former exploits; 'but we four, altogether, would be equal to thirty-six, more especially as you say the work will not be child's play. Will it last long?'

'By'r Lady! two or three years perhaps.'

'So much the better,' cried Porthos. 'You have no idea, my friend, how my bones ache since I came here. Sometimes on a Sunday, I take a ride in the fields and on the property of my neighbours, in order to pick up a nice little quarrel, which I am really in want of, but nothing happens. Either they respect or they fear me, which is more likely, but they let me trample down the clover with my dogs, insult and obstruct every one, and I come back still more weary and low-spirited, that's all. At any rate, tell me: there's more chance of fighting in Paris, is there not?'

'In that respect, my dear friend, it's delightful. No more edicts, no more of the cardinal's guards, no more De Jussacs, nor other bloodhounds. I'Gad! underneath a lamp in an inn, anywhere, they ask "Are you one of the Fronde?" They unsheathe, and that's all that is said. The Duke de Guise killed Monsieur de Coligny in the Place Royale and nothing was said of it.'

'Ah, things go on gaily, then,' said Porthos.

'Besides which, in a short time,' resumed D'Artagnan, 'We shall have set battles, cannonades, conflagrations and there will be great variety.'

'Well, then, I decide.'

'I have your word, then?'

'Yes, 'tis given. I shall fight heart and soul for Mazarin; but— '

'But?'

'But he must make me a baron.'

'Zounds!' said D'Artagnan, 'that's settled already; I will be responsible for the barony.'

On this promise being given, Porthos, who had never doubted his friend's assurance, turned back with him toward the castle.

your forty thousand francs income, the happiest man in the world, it seems to me.'

Porthos sighed.

'At the same time,' continued D'Artagnan, 'notwithstanding your forty thousand francs a year, and perhaps even for the very reason that you have forty thousand francs a year, it seems to me that a little coronet would do well on your carriage, hey?'

'Yes indeed,' said Porthos.

'Well, my dear friend, win it—it is at the point of your sword. We shall not interfere with each other—your object is a title; mine, money. If I can get enough to rebuild Artagnan, which my ancestors, impoverished by the Crusades, allowed to fall into ruins, and to buy thirty acres of land about it, that is all I wish. I shall retire and die tranquilly—at home.'

'For my part,' said Porthos, 'I desire to be made a baron.'

'You shall be one.'

'And have you not seen any of our other friends?'

'Yes, I have seen Aramis.'

'And what does he wish? To be a bishop?'

'Aramis,' answered D'Artagnan, who did not wish to undeceive Porthos, 'Aramis, fancy, has become a monk and a Jesuit, and lives like a bear. My offers did not arouse him,—did not even tempt him.'

'So much the worse! He was a clever man. And Athos?'

'I have not yet seen him. Do you know where I shall find him?'

'Near Blois. He is called Bragelonne. Only imagine, my dear friend. Athos, who was of as high birth as the emperor and who inherits one estate which gives him the title of comte, what is he to do with all those dignities—the Comte de la Fère, Comte de Bragelonne?'

'And he has no children with all these titles?'

'Ah!' said Porthos, 'I have heard that he had adopted a young man who resembles him greatly.'

'What, Athos? Our Athos, who was as virtuous as Scipio? Have you seen him?'

'No.'

'Well, I shall see him to-morrow and tell him about you; but I'm afraid, *entre nous*, that his liking for wine has aged and degraded him.'

'Yes, he used to drink a great deal,' replied Porthos.

'But I know you, my lad,' said Athos, appearing on the threshold.

'Oh, yes, monsieur le comte, you know me and I know you. I am Planchet—Planchet, whom you know well.' But the honest servant could say no more, so much was he overcome by this unexpected interview.

'What, Planchet, is Monsieur d'Artagnan here?'

'Here I am, my friend, dear Athos!' cried D'Artagnan, in a faltering voice and almost staggering from agitation.

At these words a visible emotion was expressed on the beautiful countenance and calm features of Athos. He rushed toward D'Artagnan with eyes fixed upon him and clasped him in his arms. D'Artagnan, equally moved, pressed him also closely to him, whilst tears stood in his eyes. Athos then took him by the hand and led him into the drawing-room, where there were several people. Every one arose.

'I present to you,' he said, 'Monsieur le Chevalier D'Artagnan, lieutenant of his majesty's musketeers, a devoted friend and one of the most excellent, brave gentlemen that I have ever known.'

D'Artagnan received the compliments of those who were present in his own way, and whilst the conversation became general he looked earnestly at Athos.

Strange! Athos was scarcely aged at all! His fine eyes, no longer surrounded by that dark line which nights of dissipation pencil too infallibly, seemed larger, more liquid than ever. His face, a little elongated, had gained in calm dignity what it had lost in feverish excitement. His hand, always wonderfully beautiful and strong, was set off by a ruffle of lace, like certain hands by Titian and Vandyck. He was less stiff than formerly. His long, dark hair, softly powdered here and there with silver tendrils, fell elegantly over his shoulders in wavy curls; his voice was still youthful, as if belonging to a Hercules of twenty-five, and his magnificent teeth, which he had preserved white and sound, gave an indescribable charm to his smile.

Meanwhile the guests, seeing that the two friends were longing to be alone, prepared to depart, when a noise of dogs barking resounded through the courtyard and many persons said at the same moment:

'Ah! 'tis Raoul, who is come home.'

Athos, as the name of Raoul was pronounced, looked inquisitively at D'Artagnan, in order to see if any curiosity was painted on his face. But

D'Artagnan was still in confusion and turned around almost mechanically when a fine young man of fifteen years of age, dressed simply, but in perfect taste, entered the room, raising, as he came, his hat, adorned with a long plume of scarlet feathers.

Nevertheless, D'Artagnan was struck by the appearance of this new personage. It seemed to explain to him the change in Athos; a resemblance between the boy and the man explained the mystery of this regenerated existence. He remained listening and gazing.

'Here you are, home again, Raoul,' said the comte.

'Yes, sir,' replied the youth, with deep respect, 'and I have performed the commission that you gave me.'

'But what's the matter, Raoul?' said Athos, very anxiously. 'You are pale and agitated.'

'Sir,' replied the young man, 'it is on account of an accident which has happened to our little neighbour.'

'To Mademoiselle de la Vallière?' asked Athos, quickly.

'What is it?' cried many persons present.

'She was walking with her nurse Marceline, in the place where the woodmen cut the wood, when, passing on horseback, I stopped. She saw me also and in trying to jump from the end of a pile of wood on which she had mounted, the poor child fell and was not able to rise again. I fear that she has badly sprained her ankle.'

'Oh, heavens!' cried Athos. 'And her mother, Madame de Saint-Remy, have they yet told her of it?'

'No, sir, Madame de Saint-Remy is at Blois with the Duchess of Orléans. I am afraid that what was first done was unskilful, if not worse than useless. I am come, sir, to ask your advice.'

'Send directly to Blois, Raoul; or, rather, take horse and ride immediately yourself.'

Raoul bowed.

'But where is Louise?' asked the comte.

'I have brought her here, sir, and I have deposited her in charge of Charlotte, who, till better advice comes, has bathed the foot in cold well-water.'

'No, I didn't know that. So he cherishes no resentment?'

'You are mistaken, Porthos,' said D'Artagnan. 'It is I who cherish no resentment.'

Porthos didn't understand any too clearly; but then we know that understanding was not his strong point. 'You say, then,' he continued, 'that the Count de Rochefort spoke of me to the cardinal?'

'Yes, and the queen, too.'

'The queen, do you say?'

'To inspire us with confidence she has even placed in Mazarin's hands that famous diamond—you remember all about it—that I once sold to Monsieur des Essarts and of which, I don't know how, she has regained possession.'

'But it seems to me,' said Porthos, 'that she would have done much better if she had given it back to you.'

'So I think,' replied D'Artagnan; 'but kings and queens are strange beings and have odd fancies; nevertheless, since they are the ones who have riches and honours, we are devoted to them.'

'Yes, we are devoted to them,' repeated Porthos; 'and you—to whom are you devoted now?'

'To the king, the queen, and to the cardinal; moreover, I have answered for your devotion also.'

'And you say that you have made certain conditions on my behalf?'

'Magnificent, my dear fellow, magnificent! In the first place you have plenty of money, haven't you? forty thousand francs income, I think you said.'

Porthos began to be suspicious. 'Eh! my friend,' said he, 'one never has too much money. Madame du Vallon left things in much disorder; I am not much of a hand at figures, so that I live almost from hand to mouth.'

'He is afraid I have come to borrow money,' thought D'Artagnan. 'Ah, my friend,' said he, 'it is all the better if you are in difficulties.'

'How is it all the better?'

'Yes, for his eminence will give you all that you want—land, money, and titles.'

'Ah! ah! ah!' said Porthos, opening his eyes at that last word.

'Under the other cardinal,' continued D'Artagnan, 'we didn't know enough to make our profits; this, however, doesn't concern you, with

'Really, how very amusing!'

'Yes,' replied Porthos, with a sigh, 'it *is* amusing.'

D'Artagnan now no longer counted the sighs. They were innumerable.

'However, what had you to say to me?' he resumed; 'let us return to that subject.'

'With pleasure,' replied D'Artagnan; 'I must, however, first frankly tell you that you must change your mode of life.'

'How?'

'Go into harness again, gird on your sword, run after adventures, and leave as in old times a little of your fat on the roadside.'

'Ah! hang it!' said Porthos.

'I see you are spoiled, dear friend; you are corpulent, your arm has no longer that movement of which the late cardinal's guards have so many proofs.'

'Ah! my fist is strong enough I swear,' cried Porthos, extending a hand like a shoulder of mutton.

'So much the better.'

'Are we then to go to war?'

'By my troth, yes.'

'Against whom?'

'Are you a politician, friend?'

'Not in the least.'

'Are you for Mazarin or for the princes?'

'I am for no one.'

'That is to say, you are for us. Well, I tell you that I come to you from the cardinal.'

This speech was heard by Porthos in the same sense as if it had still been in the year 1640 and related to the true cardinal.

'Ho! ho! What are the wishes of his eminence?'

'He wishes to have you in his service.'

'And who spoke to him of me?'

'Rochefort—you remember him?'

'Yes, *pardieu!* It was he who gave us so much trouble and kept us on the road so much; you gave him three sword-wounds in three separate engagements.'

'But you know he is now our friend?'

The guests now all took leave of Athos, excepting the old Duc de Barbe, who, as an old friend of the family of La Vallière, went to see little Louise and offered to take her to Blois in his carriage.

'You are right, sir,' said Athos. 'She will be the sooner with her mother. As for you, Raoul, I am sure it is your fault, some giddiness or folly.'

'No, sir, I assure you,' muttered Raoul, 'it is not.'

'Oh, no, no, I declare it is not!' cried the young girl, while Raoul turned pale at the idea of his being perhaps the cause of her disaster.

'Nevertheless, Raoul, you must go to Blois and you must make your excuses and mine to Madame de Saint-Remy.'

The youth looked pleased. He again took in his strong arms the little girl, whose pretty golden head and smiling face rested on his shoulder, and placed her gently in the carriage; then jumping on his horse with the elegance of a first-rate esquire, after bowing to Athos and D'Artagnan, he went off close by the door of the carriage, on somebody inside of which his eyes were riveted.

'I am come to give you this title'